

The Metaphysics of Race

Readings

CORE READING

Alyssa Ney and Allen Hazlett (2014) 'The Metaphysics of Race' in Ney's Metaphysics: an Introduction (Routledge).

Kwame Anthony Appiah (1994) 'Race, Culture, Identity: Misunderstood Connections' Tanner Lectures on Human Values. Also in Kwame Anthony Appiah and Amy Gutmann, eds. Color Conscious (Princeton University Press).

Charles W. Mills (2000) "'But What Are You Really?'" The Metaphysics of Race' in A. Light & N. Mechthild, eds. Race, Class, and Community Identity: Radical Philosophy Today (Humanity Books), pp. 23–51. Also in his (1998) Blackness Visible: Essays on Philosophy and Race (Cornell UP).

Sally Haslanger (2000) 'Gender and Race: (What) Are They? (What) Do We Want Them To Be?' in Noûs 34(1), pp. 31-55. Reprinted in her (2012) Resisting Reality (OUP).

For background on natural kinds as a contrast:

Koslicki, Kathrin (2008) Natural kinds and natural kind terms Philosophy Compass 3(4) 789-802

Further Reading

Faculty list sections on natural kinds and social kinds

Atkin, Albert (2012) The philosophy of race Acumen

Tommie Shelby (2002) 'Foundations of Black Solidarity: Collective Identity or Common Oppression' in Ethics 112(2), pp. 231-266.

Joshua Glasgow (2009) A Theory of Race (Routledge).

Charles W. Mills (2014) 'Notes from the Resistance: Some Comments on Sally Haslanger's Resisting Reality' in Philosophical Studies 171(1), pp. 85–97.

Quayshawn Spencer (2014) 'A Radical Solution to the Race Problem' in Philosophy of Science 81(5), pp. 1025–1038

Past Year Questions

If there weren't racism, there wouldn't be any races. Discuss [2023-2024]

'Just as the distinction between gold and fool's gold was a scientific discovery and not manifest in ordinary human behaviour, science might also discover distinctions between races that are not manifest in ordinary human behaviour.' Discuss [2022-2023]

'No adequate theory of race should have the implication that moving countries changes one's race.' Discuss. [2021-2022]

'It doesn't matter whether race is real or not – what matters is only what we believe about it.' Discuss. [2020-2021]

'Race isn't real. Hence, anti-racist politics is doomed.' Discuss. [2019-2020]

Part I: Social and Natural Kinds

Natural Kinds

Summary

Natural Kinds: Characterisation

- Natural kinds are construed as classifications that are not arbitrary, heterogeneous or gerry-mandered
 - Not kinds found in nature
 - Examples: tiger, water and also taxonomic divisions presupposed in disciplines such as medicine for example multiple sclerosis or schizophrenia or inflation
 - Controversial are classifications that may be politically charged such as Aryan or Jew or classifications that were once accepted but no longer such as phlogiston

Features of Natural Kinds

- Induction: natural kinds are said to be well suited, in comparison to other taxonomic classifications, to the task of grounding legitimate inductive inferences concerning the members of the kind in question
 - A projective quality such that we can infer that the next sample of copper will conduct electricity from the premise that all observed samples of copper in the past have been found to conduct electricity
 - Goodman: we may say that the predicate 'conducts electricity' projects with respect to members of this natural kind and the presence of this feature may be legitimately extrapolated wrt future samples
 - White things is a phony kind and deficient classification because their members lack any other common characteristics besides the feature by means of which they are categorised under a common heading (like being white or currently being in my visual field) → we call these gerry-mandered
- Laws of nature: even though something like chair captures highly useful uniformities of some sort, it is highly unlikely that any scientific law will require appeal to the category, chair, in particular, as opposed to that of material object (or body) in general
 - Classifications like copper or emerald do figure in universally quantified statements of the form 'All pieces of copper conduct electricity'
- Explanatory Role: natural kinds play an explanatory role especially in causal explanation
 - A realist about natural kinds like Putnam will point to the connections he sees between our taxonomic activity and the causal features of the world, to account for the successful results to which our explanatory and predicative practices lead → convergence between our categorisations and the actual causal features of the world which, in the mind of the realist, underlies the

important contribution made by our natural kind classifications to inductive reasoning and the formulation of scientific laws

Biological Taxa: should biological species be viewed as kinds at all

- A critic would say that biological species are in fact individuals i.e. segments of the phylogenetic tree, concrete spatiotemporally located chunks within the total genealogical nexus of life on Earth → Species as Individuals thesis i.e. SAI
 - Individual organisms on this view are parts of species rather than members or instances of them
 - Individual is best interpreted as denoting concrete particular wholes, on the SAI account, as contrasting with abstract entities in particular sets or universals
 - But the characterisation of species as individuals – (i) change over time, (ii) belong to a particular spatiotemporal phase in the development of life on Earth, (iii) their constituents stand in causal relations to one another, (iv) they are not suitable to appear in scientific laws, (v) they do not have essences; and (vi) expressions used to refer to them exhibit name-like behaviour – do not directly settle the questions of whether species belong to the ontological category of kinds
 - Dispute might just be in part terminological → we can describe species as apparently changeable, historical and cohesive entities even if they turn out to be abstract entities of some kind
 - For example, when we attribute a given characteristic to a species e.g. that it evolves, become extinct or forms a cohesive unit, our ascriptions may be understood in terms of states of affairs involving the organisms belonging to the species, namely, that these organisms adapt to their environment, are wiped out, or are subject to such evolutionary processes
 - Absence of laws → “All robins’ eggs are greenish-blue” should not count as laws because these are apparently (a) not exceptionless; (b) do not sustain counterfactual reasoning, (c) not sufficiently universal in their domain of application
 - But can science ever furnish us with exceptionless nomological generalisations, even those from domains from which uncontroversial candidates for proper scientific laws tend to be drawn e.g. physics
 - Lack of essences → Darwinian assumption creates hostile environment for essentialism for biological species since they evolve and change
 - But the truth of SAI does not immediately follow even if we accept that species lack essences → we must require that all natural kinds must have essences (but this is debatable)

- Proper names: species terms may behave like proper names, even if they are not in fact proper names and the entities they refer to do not belong to the same ontological category as the referents of proper names

Kripkean/Putnam approach to semantics of natural kind terms

- Semantics of natural kind terms have the following features
 - Rigid designators (i.e. they refer to the very same object or objects in every possible circumstance in which they refer at all)
 - They are non-descriptive (i.e. they are not synonymous with a description or a cluster of descriptions associated with them by competent speakers of the language)
 - They initially acquire their extension by means of an ostensive baptism or a descriptive stipulation, which is subsequently passed on from speaker to speaker via a causal mechanism of some sort
 - Apparent identity-statements involving rigid designators like 'Water is H₂O' are necessarily true (if true at all) but their truth is often knowable only a posteriori
 - A natural term 'water' on this analysis directly designates a natural kind, membership in which is determined by the presence of a presumed underlying common nature or essence e.g. being composed of two parts hydrogen and one part oxygen
- Arguments for the Kripke-Putnam approach
 - Suppose that the traditional descriptivist picture is correct and a natural-kind denoting general term such as 'tiger' is in fact synonymous with a description consisting of the sort of qualitative information a competent speaker of the language associates with tigers i.e. that they are four-legged, carnivores etc.
 - Following the traditional descriptivist picture, one would expect a sentence like 'Something is a tiger just in case it is a four-legged, meat-eating, cat-like animal...' to come out as analytic i.e. necessarily true and knowable a priori
 - In addition, whether an object belongs in the extension of the term, 'tiger', is determined solely by whether it exhibits the sorts of characteristics just cited
 - On the basis of modal, epistemological and semantic arguments, the traditional descriptivist analysis can be shown to be inadequate for the purposes of capturing the semantic behaviour of natural-kind denoting general terms
 - It is neither sufficient for something's being a tiger that it be superficially similar to the entities we have been calling 'tigers' in all the ways listed, nor is it necessary that the entities we call 'tigers' really have the features we have been ascribing to them

- Contrary to the descriptivist picture, a natural-kind-denoting general term like 'tiger' evidently is not used by speakers of the language in such a way that it is either necessarily true or knowable a priori that something falls into the extension of the term just in case it satisfies the descriptive information commonly associated with the term
 - We can only conclude from these arguments that only the natural-kind-denoting general terms are non-descriptive i.e. that they denote directly and are not mediated via the sort of descriptive material commonly associated by speakers with the term in question
 - But the non-descriptiveness of natural-kind-denoting general terms by itself is sufficient to mark off natural-kind-denoting general terms like water from their non-natural-kind-denoting counterparts like "bachelor" or "janitor"
 - The Kripkean approach replaces the purely semantic mechanism with a different mechanism: natural kind term extensions are determined by reference to actual-world samples in conjunction with an appeal to a same-kind relation of some sort → the details of which may not be known to competent users of the term
 - It would be counter-intuitive if it comes to us as a surprise what features members of the extension of the term might turn out to share for "janitor" or "bachelor"
- Other options for natural kinds to denote: sets, wholes or pluralities
 - But we might abandon the first two because they mean that natural-kind-denoting expressions function implicitly as singular terms rather than general terms
 - Once the rigidity requirement is abandoned, the central Kripkean arguments presented appear to be compatible with the possibility that natural kind term denotations are simply traditional predicate extensions
- Objections to the Kripke/Putnam approach to natural kind terms
 - Objection #1: Natural kind terms seem to denote substances of varying degrees of uniformities
 - Much of what we refer to as 'water' is not purely H₂O but contains impurities + the notion of isotopes (of carbon for instance)
 - 'Water' may be more heterogenous
 - Reply: We may not be immediately successful in singling out genuine divisions among natural kinds
 - Objection #2: Natural kind terms are tied through their theoretical content to particular scientific traditions in physics, chemistry and the like
 - Phlogiston and oxygen → such terms may be more susceptible to the possibility of meaning-change and the sort of incommensurability that is brought on by scientific revolutions than the Kripke/Putnam approach initially let on

- Lack of stability in the semantic behaviour of natural kind terms would lend itself more naturally to a descriptivist approach
- Reply: theoretical terms should be analysed as implicitly context-dependent or as only partially denoting a physical quantity singled out by a later theory

Quine's View

- Begins from the role of natural kinds as solving the problem of induction → that to say all emeralds are green and all emeralds are grue (green up till today and blue tomorrow) is compatible with our evidence that all current emeralds are green
 - The predicate "green", Goodman says, is projectible but "grue" is not → projectible predicates are predicates A and B whose shared instances do count, for whatever reason, toward confirmation of "All As are Bs"
- Quine proposes that the complement of a projectible predicate need not be projectible
 - "Raven" and "black" are projectible hence a black raven does count toward "All ravens are black" and hence a black raven counts indirectly toward "All non-black things are non-ravens"
 - But "non-black" and "non-ravens" are not projectible
 - Only a black raven can confirm "All ravens are black", the complements not being projectible
- If this is true, then we cannot say that "All As are Bs" is lawlike iff A and B are projectible
 - Since "All non-black things are non-ravens" is a law despite its non-projectible terms since it is equivalent to "All ravens are black"
- Why do we expect the next emerald to be green rather than grue? Quine argues that it is because of similarity no matter how subjective
 - Two green emeralds are more similar than two grue ones if only one of the grue ones were green → Green things, or at least green emeralds, are a kind
 - A projectible predicate is one that is true of all and only the things of a kind
 - Goodman's example is a puzzle only because of the dubious scientific standing of a general notion of similarity, or of kind
- Similarity is immediately definable in terms of kind: for things are similar when they are two of a kind
 - Incredibly familiar or fundamental notion
 - Hastily think of similarity in terms of sharing the number of properties
 - Properties are intensional in that they may be counted as distinct properties even though wholly coinciding in respects of the things they have in them
 - Animals with hearts and animals with kidneys
- Kinds can be seen as sets, determined by their members → just not that all sets are kinds

- Definition suggests via triadic similarity: a is more similar to b than to c when a and b belong jointly to more kinds than a and c do
 - But only works for finite systems of kinds
- Notion of kind and notion of similarity are substantially one notion but they resist reduction to less dubious notion like logic or similarity
- Paradigmatic cases: it takes in exactly the things that differ less than so-and-so much from some central norm for it to be considered a member of that kind
 - If we assume that exists one or more paradigm cases that nicely exemplify the desired norm, and one or more actual things (foils) that deviate just barely too much to be counted into the desired kind at all, then our definition is easy: the kind with paradigm a and foil b is the set of all things to which a is more similar than a is to b
 - But this also fails → let us take red and grant that a central shade of red can be picked as norm → then objects in just that shade of red can come in all sorts of shapes, weights and sizes → mere degree of overall similarity to any one such paradigm will afford little evidence of degree of weightness
 - If our assumed relation of comparative similarity were just comparative chromatic similarity, then our paradigmatic-and-foil definition of kind would accommodate redkind → what the definition will not do is distill purely chromatic kinds from mixed similarity
- Quine's conclusion is that similarity and kind is both (i) fundamental to our thinking and (ii) alien to logic and set theory
 - Fundamentality exemplified by learning by ostentation what presentations to call yellow
 - Learning a word like "apple" or "square" is more complicated because we have to learn also where to say that one apple or square leaves off and another begins
- Connection with Induction and Ostentation → animal expectation while ostensive learning of words is an implicit case of induction
 - Reasonable that our quality space should match our neighbours and we trust the worthiness of induction in the ostensive learning of words
 - But to trust induction as a way of access to truths of nature is to suppose that our quality space matches that of the cosmos
- Quine simply accepts that there are regularities in nature
 - Established fact of science → we cannot ask why there have been regularities
 - Continuity between philosophy and science → since science uses inductive generalisations, philosophy can also use inductive generalisations → philosophy is not an a priori propaedeutic or groundwork for science
- Man has developed modified systems of kinds, hence modified similarity standards for scientific purposes

- By trial-and-error process of theorizing, man has regrouped things into new kinds which prove to lend themselves to many inductions better than the old
- Using second-order induction → new groupings prove favourable to inductions and so become entrenched → newly establish the projectibility of some predicate to our satisfaction, by successfully trying to project it
- Quine points out that similarity or kinds are irreducible and instead other notions depend on similarity and kinds
 - Speaking of causality → what dissolves in water
- Quine concludes that we can take it as a very special mark of the maturity of a branch of science that it no longer needs an irreducible notion of similarity and kind
 - Final stage where the animal vestige is absorbed into the theory

Social Kinds

Hacking's Human Kinds

- Human kinds → kinds about which we would like to have a systematic, general and accurate knowledge
 - Classifications used to formulate general truths about people or generalisations sufficiently strong that they seem like laws about people, their actions, or their sentiments
- Human kinds vs Natural kinds: Hacking restricts human kinds to kind that are peculiar to people in a social setting
 - Do not deny that people are natural or that human societies are part of nature
 - But something is natural only when it is not peculiar to people in their communities
 - Human kinds are meant to mean: (i) kinds that are relevant to some of us, (ii) kinds that primarily sort people, their actions and behaviour, and (iii) kinds that are studied in the human and social sciences
- Example: homosexuality → widely asserted that although same-sex acts are common in most human societies, the idea of 'the homosexual' as a kind of people came into being only late into the 19th century as homosexual behaviour became an object of scientific scrutiny
 - If this is correct, then homosexual behaviour is what Hacking calls a human kind
- Paradigmatic social categories: race and gender → Hacking ignores these as it is redolent with political ideology
- Interpretation of human kinds as with "social meaning" → cultural meaning imbued in phrases like "teenage pregnancy" as it was introduced by sociologists
 - Denoted white American suburbs of the 1960s and the black urban ghettos of the 1990s → can be completely grounded in nature 'teenage' + 'pregnancy' but it is a human kind and is the subject of social science

- Adolescence also cannot be fully grounded in nature → its end is denoted by social meanings and contexts
- Current objects of social kinds analysis
 - Child abuse: peculiar to many people, kind of behaviour which we would like to have knowledge and inclination to project the kind of behaviour to the person i.e. to abuser
- Hacking argues that human kinds need not be indubitably real in that they are cross-culturally cosmic
 - Multiple personality disorder is now accepted as the consequence of repeated trauma early in childhood, almost always involving sexual abuse → almost considered definitional
 - Interactional aspect: Hacking says that the people of the kind (like homosexuals) may rise up against the experts and the known may overpower the knowers
 - Want to be able to predict their behaviours in order to 'help' them
- Human kinds are meant as kinds of people and their behaviour which (it is hoped) can enter into practical laws → but they are not at worst messy natural kinds
 - Hacking does not argue for a constructionist position for human kinds: human kinds differs from the naturals but not because human kinds are to be understood hermeneutically rather than explained by causal principles and not because human kinds are social constructions while natural kinds are discovered in nature
 - Hacking thinks the distinction between natural and human kinds are shallow
- Human kinds and social constructions
 - It may very well be said that everything is social → some contend that it is misleading to talk about scientific discoveries
 - Hacking thinks that facts are socially constructed and so are the kinds about which there are facts → but within the domain of social constructions, he can still claim that there is an important difference between quarks and tripeptides on the one hand, and human kinds on the other
 - Multiple personality disorder and adolescence are just as real as electricity and sulphuric acid
 - There is no vital contradiction between constructivism and realism
 - Teenage pregnancy is both 'real' (as could be with rigorous defining characteristics) and socially constructed
- Difference between human kinds and natural kinds: Looping
 - Prima facie, the difference between human kinds and natural kinds are that human kinds are value-laden (child-abuse is bad) while natural kinds tend to be value-neutral

- Human kinds are kinds that people may or may not want to be but if N is a natural kind and Z is an N, it makes no difference to Z if it's called an N
- If H is a human kind and A is a person, then calling A H may make us treat A differently, just as calling Z N may make us do something to Z
 - But it also makes a difference to A to know that A is an H precisely because there is so often a moral connotation to a human kind
- Anscombe "under a description": intentional actions are to do something "under a description" → human kinds enable us to redescribe our past to the extent that people can come to experience new pasts
 - People come to realise that they were in fact abused
- Human kinds differ, crucially, in that classifying people works on people, changes them and can even change their past
 - People of a kind themselves change and the experts are forced to rethink our classifications
 - Sometimes they confirm our definitions so much that they become essential definitional connotations
 - Looping effect is what this is called
- Objections
 - Selectively choosing examples and evidence is skimpy
 - Thesis rests on special pleading and too judicious choices of examples
- Self-consciousness: people of a kind can become self-conscious about that kind
 - Some human beings cannot access their own kind like infants
 - However, there can be looping that involves a larger unit, for example the family → having the term infant changes how the family unit is constructed and acts and views itself → not just how they act

Cooper's objection: human kinds can still be natural kinds

Main objection

- Hacking's central thesis that human kinds cannot be natural kinds rests on the claim that classifying and describing human kinds results in feedback which alters the very kinds under study
 - Homosexuals respond to be studied in ways insects do not
 - The feedback loop that Hacking says differentiates human kinds from natural kinds operates both at the cultural and the conceptual level
- Cooper argues that for each type of feedback, insofar as feedback occurs, it is compatible with human kinds being natural kinds

Natural Kinds

- Essentialist accounts of natural kinds don't work because of the evolutionary nature of biological species, which we consider paradigmatic cases of natural kinds
 - So because they fundamentally change, no essences can be found
 - But some bite the bullet and suggest that if no essence is to be found, then

those biological species are not natural kinds

- Some reject essentialism and take three accounts
 - Promiscuous realism: Dupre asks us to imagine the individual entities of some domain mapped out on a multidimensional quality space and that we would find clusters corresponding to groups of similar entities → messy and hard to make out and we would find even more clusters within by going in deeper
 - Homeostatic mechanisms: Boyd suggests that there is a homeostatic mechanism that makes it such that groups possess a cluster of regularly co-occurring properties → Boyd suggests this can help us understand human kinds too
 - Species as individuals: Millikan suggests that species can be considered to be individuals instead since they develop and eventually die
 - Unlike actual individuals, they can be spatially dispersed → but explains how we can run inductive inference over the members of a species
 - Cooper follows Hacking in deciding that we need not go into the metaphysical character of natural kinds, and can understand them intuitively (following Quine too) → paradigmatic cases of natural kinds are biological species and chemicals, physical particles etc
- Main thing Hacking claims is that natural kinds cannot be affected by classificatory practices
 - So human kinds cannot be natural kinds

Hacking's feedback mechanism and objections

- Cultural feedback: dependent on the description of a kind of person entering popular culture → alcoholic etc
 - Being classified in a certain way carries institutionalised benefits, motivating people to act in a certain way
 - Bogen points out that because marijuana is illegal, it has been grown in attics, changing its appearance → so Hacking's argument cannot rest not merely on the fact that feedback occurs but rather on the fact that it occurs in a particular way → specifically, that subjects become aware of the ways in which they are being described and judged
 - But this may not be enough to show that this difference is of fundamental significance
 - Cooper suggests that an extra premise must be added, to the effect that being affected by ideas is of greater metaphysical significance than being affected by, say, antibiotics
 - Idea-dependence may be said to matter because it betrays a subjective nature of some kind → natural kinds are not subjective in this way
 - But there are two senses in which something can be idea-dependent and only one of this is subjective (hence objectivity is compatible with it being

subjective)

- Two senses in which “female beauty” affect entities: in one case a woman is influenced by images of the idea female form decided she is too fat and slims → her altered shape is idea-dependent in the sense that her ideas concerning her weight caused her to slim
- The development of the Concorde was also dependent on the ideas of its developers in the same sort of way for aeroplane designs
- Nevertheless, despite being in a sense ‘idea-dependent’, the reduction in the woman’s weight, the building of Concorde, are both perfectly objective
- Idea-dependence of this type results in objective changes in entities and is perfectly compatible with a kind of being objective
- On the other hand, consider the case of the first Miss World, who looks short and plump by today’s standards even though she looked fine at the time → nothing about Miss World has changed but our perception of her has changed → this only shows that “attractive woman” is merely a subjective kind and so not a natural kind
- So, Hacking needs to show, on top of the fact that human kinds are idea-dependent, that they are also idea-dependent in producing relational and not genuine changes
- Hacking’s example of Multiple Personality Disorder seems to give rise to genuine changes in people presenting symptoms after it has entered into popular culture: but in order to show that the changes in symptoms of multiple personality disorder indicate that it is not a natural kind, he would need to show that barking, like beauty, is in the eye of the beholder
 - More like Barking as interpreted as part of MPD which he claims
- Conceptual feedback
 - Dependent on Anscombe’s account of intentional action: an action X can be said to be intentional when the actor could respond to the question ‘Why are you doing X?’ by giving a reason for acting
 - And if intentional actions make us the kind of person we are, then creating new descriptions makes it logically possible to create new kinds of persons
 - But Cooper argues that Anscombe really means “under a description” as “qua” → so “A may, qua B, receive such-and-such a salary” etc → so intentional action is only intentional qua some aspect
 - So, it is more permissible than the Why test → other ways in which we can decide to find out what someone intends by considering their probable motives even if they cannot access their concepts
 - Like a caveman who does not know what a fire is → but we can still say he intentionally lit a fire → allows observers to infer an agent’s intention by attributing intentions that are appropriate for them

- The upshot of this is that Hacking wrongly presumes that the conditions under which an intentional action can be performed are identical to the conditions under which an observer can infer the actor's intentions
 - So even before the creation of terms such as homosexual, gay people are already acting, qua gay person

Part II: Views on Race

Summary

Ontology of Natural and Social Kinds

- Consider biological classifications of species such as hammerhead sharks vs the Borgesian classification based on animals that are trained, belonged to the emperor etc
 - Biological system groups animals into natural kinds while Borgesian system does not and seems to be subjective
 - Biological system seems to group them according to their morphology → why is morphology more natural than classifying by ownership?
 - Intrinsic vs extrinsic properties: extrinsic properties are relational while intrinsic properties are something that an object just has
 - However, contemporary biology does not classify animals by morphology and instead their relationship to other members of that species and have the same ancestors
- Social kinds: like professors, people who are wives or husbands etc
 - Haslanger: the distinction...between people who are cool and people who are uncool...is not capturing intrinsic differences between people; rather it is a distinction marking certain social relations – i.e. it distinguishes status or in-group...The distinction does not capture a difference in the individuals so-called except insofar as they are related to me...and its use in this context is determined not by the intrinsic or objective coolness of the individuals but by the social task of establishing a cohort
 - Social kinds can be considered a social construction → link with modal notions of necessity and contingency → social kinds depend on social practices, institutions and conventions but these could've been different
- Three views on race: Biological Realism, Social Constructivism, Eliminativism
- Biological Realism: Race are natural kinds; in particular racial categories are biological categories akin to subspecies or breeds
 - Argument from Genetics:
 - Appiah says that biological realism is committed to racialism i.e. “the view that there are heritable characteristics, possessed by members of our species, which allow us to divide them into a small set of races, in such a way that all the members of these races share certain traits and tendencies with each other that they do not share with members of any other race”
 - Not just or even about morphological differences → redheads and freckled is a morphological difference but not a biological category
 - About a set of “traits and tendencies” beyond morphological differences → morphology is just a proxy for what underlies one's biology

- Objection from biology : (i) If racial categories weren't biological categories, there would be genetic differences between races, beyond those related to morphology; (ii) there aren't genetic differences between races, except those related to morphology; (iii) therefore, racial categories aren't biological categories
 - Appiah: few genetic characteristics to be found in the population of England that are not found in similar populations in Zaire or China → hard to say what his or her biological characteristics (apart from those all human being share) will be, except in respect of the "grosser" features of colour, hair, and bone
 - Biological realists may challenge (ii) i.e. that black people are more common to get sickle-cell disease → pretty weak
- Reply: challenge (i) that races are ancestor-descendant sequences of breeding populations that share a common origin
 - Based on shared history
- Objection from anti-racism: biological realism is essentially racist by developing negative or moralised stereotypes of particular races
 - Most biological realists have attached harmful stereotypes
 - But can racial categories be freed from any cultural racist or racist presuppositions? → some people think it cannot just as "witch" cannot be freed from its negative connotations BUT harmonie granger is a witch
- Social Constructivist: Races are a social construction and they can argue, following Haslanger's example of cool and uncool people, that the classification of races are essentially hierarchical and racist
 - Haslanger articulates a social constructivism about race according to which "races are those groups demarcated by the geographical associations accompanying perceived body type, when those associations take on evaluative significance concerning how members of the group should be viewed and treated"
 - For Haslanger, to be a member of a race is to be racialised, which is to be systematically subordinated or privileged in virtue of being perceived as "appropriately occupying certain kinds of social positions" → does not exclude the biological input into the classification but just that social factors plays a role
 - Argument from relativism: natural kinds seem to be absolute → chemical elements are natural kinds and hence there is absolutely one correct periodic table and not a plurality of equally correct periodic table
 - Census data collection is done extremely different across countries: South Africa offers Black, African, Coloured, Indian, or Asian and White while Brazil offered White, Black, Yellow, Brown and Aboriginal

- The relativists assert that there is no correct way of classification → is this actually true? → might instead be that there is no correct way of answering rather
- Formally: (i) If races were natural kinds, there would be one correct system of racial classification, (ii) there exists multiple, equally correct systems of racial classification, (iii) therefore, races aren't natural kinds
- Some may reject (ii) → anyway isn't this begging the question?
 - Andreassen proposes an 'objective' method of classification
 - Stronger: just because we don't know how to classify doesn't mean they're equally correct
- Eliminativism: there are no races; racial attributions are false. The case of race is analogous to that of witch-hood. There are no witches and the accusations are false. Race is neither biologically nor socially real
 - Social Constructivism and Biological Realism entail that races are real i.e. committed to their ontology
 - Causal Argument against Eliminativism: based on Alexander's dictum that entities which exist are all and only those that possess causal powers
 - If races have causal powers, then we should have an ontological commitment to them
 - Races have causal powers, given racial oppression
 - Hence we ought to have an ontological commitment to them
 - Reply: the eliminativist may reply – that we have internalised a false system of classification – denying the underlying premise that something 'real' must have causal powers

Haslanger's View on Race as connected with oppression

Central Thesis: views gender and race as fundamentally a social construction, and that what defines them is precisely the subordination they face

- What is race is followed by three projects
 - Conceptual inquiry: articulation of our concepts of race and gender via an effective equilibrium
 - Descriptive project: focuses on the extension of our concepts
 - Need not be restricted to natural kinds but can talk about social kinds such as democracy or human rights
 - Analytical approach: understanding the pragmatics underlying our concepts → what is the point of having these concepts → a practical view on "What is gender/race"
 - Responsibility to define them for our purposes
 - Haslanger takes this route: in understanding why the concepts of race and gender are important to us, she seeks to definition to make sense of our practical usage of these terms

- Not committed to anything about their actual ontology
- Critical (Feminist) Theory: guided by the goal of more than knowledge/JTB
 - Good theories are systematic bodies of knowledge that address our broader cognitive and practical demands
 - Critical analytical approach to “What is gender” and “What is race”
 - Guided by 4 concerns
 - Explain inequalities between females and males and between races; how social forces, under the guise of biological differences, work to perpetuate such inequalities
 - Need for a framework that will be sensitive to both similarities and differences among males and females, and the similarities and differences among individuals in groups demarcated by “colour” → includes the concern to identify the effects of interlocking oppressions (intersectionality of race and gender)
 - Need for an account that will track how gender and race are implicated in a broad range of social phenomena beyond those that obviously concern sexual or racial differences (how art, religion, law might be gendered or racialised)
 - Need for accounts of gender and race that take seriously the agency of women and people of colour of both genders, and within which we can develop an understanding of agency that will aid feminist and antiracist efforts to empower critical social agents
 - Caution in regarding races and gender as purely natural categories because they have always been socially significant
- Considerations about Gender
 - Commonality Problem: is there anything social that females have in common that could count as their gender → cross-culturally cosmic
 - Normativity Problem: any definition of “what woman is” is value-laden and will marginalise certain females, privilege others, and reinforce current gender norms
 - Emphasis of the analytical project is not discovering commonalities but to provide an analysis that will serve as a tool for justice
 - Critical project embraces normative results and begins from an analysis of normative results
 - Marxian materialist strategy in connecting oppression with gender but expanding the materialist strategy to include noneconomic forces of oppression
 - Gender categories are defined in terms of how one is socially positioned, where this is a function of e.g. how one is viewed, treated, one’s life is structured socially, legally, and economically; gender is not

defined in terms of an individual's intrinsic physical or psychological features

- Gender categories are defined hierarchically within a broader complex of oppressive relations; one group is socially subordinate to the other, typically within the context of other forms of economic and social oppression
- Sexual difference functions as the physical marker to distinguish between two groups, and is used in the justification of viewing and treating members of each group differently
- Tentatively: S is a woman iff S is systematically subordinated along some dimension and S is "marked" as a target for this treatment by observed or imagined bodily features presumed to be evidence of a female's biological role in reproduction
 - S is a man iff S is systematically privileged...
- So while a Brazilian woman of the 1890s and American woman of the 1990s may involve very different social relations, and very different kinds of oppression, the definition suggested is broad enough to count them as women insofar as their subordinate positions
 - Oppression in terms of exploitation, marginalisation, powerlessness, cultural imperialism, and systematic violence
- In what sense is someone marked: in the context of oppression, certain properties of individuals are socially meaningful → play a role in a broadly accepted representation of the world that function to justify and motivate particular forms of social intercourse
 - Most of us develop relatively fixed gender identity by age three → degree to which the marked body makes a difference varies from context to context
- More fully, S is a woman iff (i) S is regularly and for the most part observed or imagined to have certain bodily features presumed to be evidence of a female's biological role in reproduction; (ii) that S has these features marks S within the dominant ideology of S's society as someone who ought to occupy certain kinds of social position that are in fact subordinate; and (iii) the fact that S satisfies (i) and (ii) plays a role in S's systematic subordination i.e. along some dimension, S's social position is oppressive, and S's satisfying (i) and (ii) plays a role in that dimension of subordination
 - Upshot: a woman may not always function socially as a woman; a man may not always function socially as a man
 - When systems of White supremacy and male dominance collide, the Black man's privilege may be seen as threatening that it must be violently wrestled from him

- S functions as a woman in context C iff (i) S is observed or imagined in C to have certain bodily features presumed to be evidence of a female's biological role in reproduction; (ii) that S has these features marks S within the background ideology of C as someone who thought to occupy certain kinds of social position that are in fact subordinate; and (iii) the fact that S satisfies (i) and (ii) plays a role in S's systematic subordination in C, i.e. along some dimension, S's social position in C is oppressive, and S's satisfying (i) and (ii) plays a role in that dimension of subordination
- Race: parallel with gender
 - Haslanger argues that even if race is a biological fiction, it is at least socially real
 - Parallel with gender: A group is racialised iff its members are socially positioned as subordinate or privileged along some dimension and the group is marked as a target for this treatment by observed or imagined bodily features presumed to be evidence of ancestral links to some geographical region
 - More elaborated, a group G is racialised relative to context C iff members of G are (all and only) those: (i) who are observed or imagined to have certain bodily features presumed in C to be evidence of ancestral links to a certain geographical region, (ii) whose having (or imagined to have) these features marks them within the context of the background ideology in C as appropriately occupying certain kinds of social position that are in fact either subordinate or privileged (and so motivates and justifies their occupying such a position); and (iii) whose satisfying (i) and (ii) plays (or would play) a role in their systematic subordination of privilege in C i.e., who are along some dimension systematically subordinated or privileged when in C, and satisfying (i) and (ii) plays (or would play) a role in that dimension of privilege or subordination
 - Contrast between race and ethnicity: ethnicity concerns one's ancestral links to certain geographical region and may be purely physical → ethnic groups can be racialised and thus gain a moral connotation and a hierarchical structure
- Connection with commonality
 - Women are said to be those who occupy a certain kind of social position → but these are all relative and not an intrinsic property
- Seeks to offer a negative definition intended to challenge male and racial dominance
- Objection from commonality: some women who aren't oppressed and aren't oppressed as women because they pass as men
 - Haslanger says that there could be females who aren't women in the sense she has defined and thus are not counterexamples to the analysis intended to capture meaningful political categories for critical feminist efforts

- Objection from normativity: the definition of women still privileges and marginalises some women by regarding them as not “real” women
 - Haslanger: Important to choose which facts are significant on the basis of explicit and considered values
- Haslanger argues that the norms that underpin social groups are not fixed
 - What it means to be a woman, or to be White or Latino in this sense is unstable and always open to contest
 - As social roles change, the contents of normative race and gender identities adjust
 - But as social roles change and become less hierarchical or even non-hierarchical, since the definitions of man and woman are hierarchical and opposed, Haslanger proposes the **creation of new, non-hierarchical genders**, offering a generic definition of G is a gender relative to context C iff [the generalised definition but maintaining “reproductive capacities associated with G”]
 - Creation of alternative, new genders and races to break the binary opposition between White/Black, Man/Woman
- Objection from Persistence: The category of woman or some race ceases to exist once oppression ceases to exist
 - But surely this is important to the history of some category?
 - To be able to see their history as a triumphant struggle is what matters to them (to use a Parfitian phrase) → a continuity beyond struggle

Mills’ intersubjectivist view on race

Central Thesis: proposes an intersubjectivist view that race depends on institutional forces, i.e. a racial contract, that excludes and marginalises certain groups. In other words, races are defined not just by the members of the group, but also by members outside the group, and this answers his central question “What are you really?”

Quace vs Race

- Hypothetical, contrasting system that could be termed quace → imagine a nation in which at birth, all citizens are assigned a code – Q1, Q2, Q3 – that indicates their “quacial” membership; the assignment is done randomly, there is no connection between quace and an individual’s morphology or genealogy
 - Quace will have no deeper significance to the lives of the people in that society beyond bureaucratic irritation → “I am a Q1” will have no metaphysical ring
 - Declarations of race has a deeper significance
- Idea Horizontal and Vertical distributions of race: in the former, races are morphologically or genealogically connected but are completely disconnected from one’s socioeconomic or political status; in the latter, it is the opposite

- Vertical system will have immense significance since it will indicate one's social standing and profoundly affect one's life
- Also, racial systems have not been complete, nor perfect in that it has been ambiguous and led to the phenomena of "race traitors"
- Must ask "what are you really" which has ontological import
- Constructivism has intersubjectivist agreement → analogous to Rawls' veil of ignorance where agreement depends on multiple people
 - The objective ontological status that is involved arises out of intersubjectivity and though it is not naturally based, is real for all that
 - So objectivism does not entail that race is foundational: in different systems, races could have been constructed quite differently
 - For racial realism, the social metaphysics is an outgrowth of a natural metaphysics; for racial constructivism, there is no natural metaphysics, and the social metaphysics arises directly out of the social history
 - So there is nothing natural about race for the realist
 - Because people come to think of themselves as "race", as black and white for example, these categories, which correspond to no natural kinds, attain a social reality → intersubjectivity creates a certain kind of objectivity
- Mills is sympathetic to the constructionist idea that is both anti-realist and anti-essentialist
 - Purely emerging from intersubjective agreement
- Criteria for racial identity: considerations of identity – (i) bodily appearance, (ii) ancestry, (iii) self-awareness of ancestry, (iv) public awareness of ancestry, (v) culture, (vi) experience, (vii) subjective identification (what one sees oneself as – conceptually separated from self-awareness of ancestry)
- Problem Case 1: deliberately passing as a privileged race by being naturally white but has at least one black ancestor
 - Famous theme of the African American experience → passing for the purpose of taking advantage of differential economic opportunities in a segregated workplace or a better residential area or for whatever reason but continuing to think of himself and maintaining contact with the black community
 - Public will generally not know such people are black and so they will not have many of the negative encounters characteristic of the black experience → nonetheless, we would generally conclude that these individuals, identifying with and acculturated by the black community, are indeed "really" black
 - We would always say they are black but sometimes pretend to be White
- Problem Case 2: conscious permanent passing → the person wants to be taken for as white and thus sever all relationships and give one's children a highly pruned version of the family tree

- Accepted by the public as white and there is no public awareness in his social world of his black ancestry → does not experience racism and feels confident he will never be discovered
- Clearly, changed his apparent race but what about his real race → constructivism about race implies that there are objective criteria to being a member of a race
 - Biologists think that this criteria is biological while subjectivists think that one can simply will himself to be white
- But because he is always anticipating exposure as black, the phenomenological difference between the consciousness of the “real” white person and the apparent white person is alone sufficient to show that the person cannot be really white but is still black
 - So, there is also an objective phenomenological criteria of the “white experience” that is beyond racism → but also connected to positions of power and privilege → doesn’t really have privilege
- Problem Case 3: Passing without awareness of his nonwhite ancestry and the person thinks himself of as white even though he does not have purely white ancestry
 - For a constructivist against a realist theory, ancestry is crucial not because it necessarily manifests itself in biological racial traits but simply because it is taken to be crucial by others, as there is an intersubjective agreement to classify individuals in a certain way on the basis of known ancestry
 - But there is a possibility that there is an intersubjective classification is mistaken, which makes one not think of oneself in that way, and not identify with that culture, not have these experiences
 - So it is not clear what someone is *really* → Maria Hertough case in Singapore
 - But Mills thinks that it is not just an error of classification, but shows that making the ancestral criterion the sole arbiter in our intersubjective agreement fails to capture the metaphysical dimension of how significant being classified as a certain race can be (as opposed to the consequenceless quace) because then we’re reduced to saying that race is just how an individual is classified
 - The reality is that it is the import of this classification that, through subjective internalisation and intersubjective recognition, is doing the metaphysical work
 - What is important is the intersubjective/subjective criterion of what ancestry is thought to be, not ancestry as is
 - This remains to be objective because construction is intersubjectivist (not individual), state-backed, and usually crystallised both in law and custom
- Problem Case 4: Mills talks about someone, Mr Oreo, who goes through a machine that creates a cosmetic transformation such that Mr Oreo becomes completely white

- Analogy: if we had a machine that made scrawny men massively muscled and strong, would we say they have only become apparently and not really strong?
 - There may be an ontological depth for race that is not captured in this analogy
- One may say that Mr Oreo's transformation is unreal because it is artificial but artificiality contrasts with naturalness
 - This makes no difference to reality
- What matters is whether there is intersubjective agreement over whether one is considered part of the race or not → so if Mr Oreo is agreed upon to be white, he is really white and successfully changed
- I think that Mills fails to differentiate between perfect agreement and imperfect agreement → imperfect agreement is due to incomplete information and so if they discovered Mr Oreo's history, they may consider him to not be part of it
 - Objection: perfect agreement then makes it based on the whims of the community → wouldn't this just collapse into ancestry?
 - But consider the Maria Hertough case → considerations over what counts as part of the community is broader than that → cultural dimensions as well
- Problem Case 5: someone who is ancestrally white, unaware of his actual parentage, is also categorised as black and thinks of himself as black
 - Do we consider him white or black? → probably black
- Problem Case 6: biracialism → traditional shade hierarchies and become more complicated in Latin America
 - Can, in the face of majority white resistance to such revision, whether subgroups within the existing bipolar system can successfully construct themselves as biracial
 - Group decision to challenge dominant conceptions
 - Would such a people really become another race or would their interactions with the larger society force them to stay black? I think there is a priority of group self-determination

Appiah's Eliminativist View

- *Racial skepticism* holds that because racial naturalism is false, races of any type do not exist. Racial skeptics, such as Anthony Appiah (1995, 1996) and Naomi Zack (1993, 2002) contend that the term race cannot refer to anything real in the world, since the one thing in the world to which the term could uniquely refer—discrete, essentialist, biological races—have been proven not to exist.
 - Zack (2002, 87–88) provides an accessible summary of the racial skeptic's argument against the biological foundations for race, sequentially

summarizing the scientific rejection of essences, geography, phenotypes, post-Mendelian transmission genetics, and genealogies as possible foundations for races. Aristotelian *essences*, thought to ground the common characteristics of distinct species, were correctly rejected by early modern philosophers. If essences cannot even ground differences among species, then they clearly cannot ground the differences among races, which even nineteenth century racial science still understood as members of the same species.

- Clearly, Appiah begins from a naturalistic definition of real
- Racial skeptics like Appiah and Zack adopt normative racial *eliminativism*, which recommends discarding the concept of race entirely, according to the following argument. Because of its historical genealogy, the term race can only refer to one or more discrete groups of people who alone share biologically significant genetic features.
 - Such a monopoly on certain genetic features could only emerge within a group that practices such a high level of inbreeding that it is effectively genetically isolated. Such genetic isolation might refer to the Amish in America (Appiah 1996, 73) or to Irish Protestants (Zack 2002, 69), but they clearly cannot refer to those groupings of people presently subsumed under American racial census categories.
 - Because the concept “race” can only apply to groups not typically deemed races (Amish, Irish Protestants), and because this concept cannot apply to groups typically deemed races (African Americans, Whites, Asians, Native Americans), a mismatch occurs between the concept and its typical referent. Thus, the concept of race must be eliminated due to its logical incoherence
 - There is fundamentally a **failure of correspondence** between concepts of race and even culture and our intended referents
- Appiah has since modified his skepticism in such a way that softens the eliminativist element of his position. Appiah has come to argue for *racial nominalism* by admitting the importance of “human folk races,” namely, that they are **forms of social identity that do in fact exist** (2006, 367). The way in which they are social identities, however, is a problem because we treat them *as if* there were some biological underpinning to them (2006, 367). The folk theory of race, then, is false because it is based on mistaken beliefs, yet it is nonetheless true that we continue to categorize people along its lines. Appiah’s nominalist view of race aims to reveal how these social identities work by analyzing the labels we use for them.
 - According to Appiah there are three ways that we categorize using folk racial labels: ascription, identification, and treatment, and it takes all three for a given label to be a functioning social identity (2006, 368–370). As a result, we come to live as these identities and look to them as a central resource for constructing our lives.

- Furthermore, norms of identification and authenticity arise around them (2006, 372). Since there is no biological story that can be told to ground these labels then race is not real (2006, 372).

Mill's review on Haslanger's Book Resisting Reality: Sophisticated eliminativism

- Haslanger defends a form of constructionism that is "compatible with important forms of realism, an objectivism about kinds, and naturalism" which is congenial with Mill's own "objectivist" constructionist position → so not radically subjective
- More sophisticated eliminativists have risen such as Glasgow who has advocated for a reconstructionist programme in which we replace "race" with "race*" and Kitcher who argue that in a sense the opposition between constructionism and biologism is misguided
 - Social-natural hybrid analysis were suggested very early on → and even if races as we knew them were socially constructed, it did not follow that natural races did not exist also
- Andreasen argues for a "cladistic approach to sub-species...races are ancestor-descendant sequences of breeding populations, or groups of such sequences, that share a common-origin"
 - This view of races as clades offers no support for racism → a biologically objective way to divide individuals into races rather than biologically vindicating our common views on race
- Kitcher also suggested that inbreeding via isolation is also in part due to social forces of inaccessibility : because they were labeled mistakenly as intrinsically different, it has given rise to the separation of their way of life from the labelers → both socially constructed and biologically real
- Two kinds of challenge for Haslanger and constructionists: is the social/natural contrast useful or even clear? And is it possible that race is neither social nor natural
 - A nouveau eliminativism denies the truth of both biologism and constructionism while seeking to recuperate the social truth aspired to by the latter through offering a substitutionist discourse on race, reconstructionist rather than constructionist
 - Glasgow's reconstructionist account argues that constructionists have failed to rehabilitate the concept of race as a social kind because a biological reference is built into the concept:
 - Our race talk is predicated on a conceptually non-negotiable but factually false belief, namely that we fall into biological races. This contrasts with decisively social kinds, like professional kinds...Thus constructivism seems to heavily revise our understanding of "race", and consequently, we need to ask whether that revision is so heavy that it no longer represents "race" in the ordinary sense

- Glasgow attempts to show that the radical divergence between implications of the constructionist conception of race and everyday conception is there and that the conclusion is that the constructionist salvage operation fails → what has survived is not “race” but a concept with some similarities but crucial difference that rules out its being presented as a successor-concept
- Possible reply: make use of the claims of Andreassen and Kitcher to argue for a socionatural conception which concedes only a thin biology and use that residue, attenuated as it may be, to justify the ancestral link with the folk conception
- Possible reply: Deny Glasgow’s intuitions that biology is part of the concept for most language speakers
 - Or even if biological is part of the folk conception, this is because the folk conception is naively relying on biology to explain the radical “racial” differences → but since now these differences can be given a superior explanation, so that a revisionist concept can be defended, we can revise the assumptions embedded in our language
- Defining race
 - Haslanger argues that a disanalogy between gender and race is that whereas we would want to allow for “new egalitarian genders” after the revolution, race is different, and what we would expect is that ethnicity will survive the revolution, but not race
 - Further asymmetry between gender and race: although all societies will perforce have some kind of gender relations, since women are going to be half the population, it is controversial whether all societies have had races (Japan)
 - Most theorists of race believe that there is a pre-racial period even if they disagree on its chronology
 - Also, Mills wonders if Haslanger’s proposed conceptualisation would handle European varieties of racism and changes of racial status because Europe is not a geographical monolith and that there are obvious cases of regional distinctions such as anti-Irish, anti-Semitism, and anti-Slavism or differences between Nordics/Teutons as varieties of white races
 - Overtly geographically marked rather than physically present
 - How does her proposal handle movement across races → how the Irish become White

Shelby’s Analysis of Causal interactions with Race

Central Thesis: Shelby intends to make sense of the necessity of unifying collective agent of social change and collective solidarity but argues that it is not essential to fighting against oppression

- Theories over solidaristic commitment

- Common oppression theory: Blacks should unite and work together because they suffer a common oppression; and they can overcome or ameliorate their shared condition only through black solidarity
 - Simply acknowledges the existence of antiblack racism and calls on those who suffer under it to act collectively to end that oppression or at least to reduce its impact on their lives → free blacks from antiblack racism
- Collective self-determination theory: Blacks should unite and work together because they are oppressed people, a people with their own distinctive racial, ethnic, cultural, and/or national identity; and as a people, blacks have interests that are best served by their becoming a self-determining group
 - Form of black nationalism and maintains that blacks need to work together
- Argues that common oppression theory is misunderstood and does not require the severe sacrifices that collective self-determination theory demands
 - Merely by cultivating a common conception of who they are as black people, blacks can strengthen the bonds of sympathy and loyalty that will enable them to overcome these barriers to collective action
 - Firmer basis for mutual identification across class lines
 - Normative aspects: mere acceptance of abstract principles of justice is often insufficient to motivate people to contribute the time and resources necessary for effecting meaningful social change
- Against the duty-based imposition: reject the view that a collective, singular black identity is a necessary component of an emancipatory black solidarity not because it has no contribution to make to black liberation but rather because cultivating a collective black identity is unnecessary for forging effective bonds among blacks and would create undue constraint on individual freedom, and is likely to be self defeating
 - Disentangle the call for an emancipatory black solidarity from the call for a collective black identity → need not be essential
 - A black solidarity based on the common experience of antiblack racism and joint commitment to bringing it to an end can and should play an important role in the fight against racial injustice
 - But an emancipatory black solidarity that emphasises the need to affirm a racial, ethnic, cultural and/or national identity must be abandoned for the sake of the struggle
- Group solidarity is created via (i) identification between members, (ii) shared values or goals, (iii) group loyalty, (iv) mutual trust
- Thin and thick conceptions of black identity

- On the thin conception, “black” is a vague and socially imposed category of difference that serves to distinguish groups on the basis of their members having visible, inherited physical characteristics and/or biological ancestry
 - One cannot choose to be thinly black
- A thick conception of black identity always requires something more than a common physical appearance → narrower social meaning
 - Racialist conception of blackness: based on the supposed presence of a special genotype in the biological make-up of all fully black people that does not exist among nonblacks
 - Ethnic conception of blackness that treats black identity as a matter of shared ancestry and common cultural heritage → no assumption that two people of the same ethnicity must necessarily share the same “racial essence”
 - Cultural conception of blackness → claim that there is an identifiable set of beliefs, values, behaviours and practices that has come to be associated with the thin black because of their role in creating it
 - Reproduction of the common way of life
 - Kinship conception of blackness → understands black identity on the model of family → regarding others as brothers or sisters even though they are not actually family
- Reasons to reject black identity can because one might think that it is not an apt characterisation of what they would like to be/too crude or limiting
- We can say that someone who satisfies the thin but not thick criterion is not “really black”
 - For instance, criticised for not being sufficiently loyal
- Against collective identity theory
 - Strong version of cultural/ethnic view: blacks must share a common ethnic or cultural identity if emancipatory black solidarity is to flourish
 - Weak version of cultural ethnic view: a collective black identity is not claimed to be necessary for black solidarity, since blacks might get by without one, but it is thought that such an identity strengthens the bonds of black unity by giving them more in common than just the history of oppression
 - But Shelby thinks that there is little reason to suppose that blacks must share a collective identity in order for them to exhibit, as a group, each of the four characteristics of robust solidarity
 - Sharing common ethnic or cultural values/practices is not necessary for blacks to identify with one another → they can identify with one another via shared experiences of racism
 - Shelby is not saying, unlike Haslanger, that shared oppression amounts to identity

- Loyalty can exist between blacks with diverse ethnic/cultural identities as well such as those between diverse members of an organisation → can foster mutual trust
- Black identity is not constructive
 - Push would worsen intragroup antagonisms and might product new ones within the black community
 - Internal struggle over what constitutes an “authentic” black identity
 - How much of cultural history i.e. slavery should they embrace
 - Class differences also complicate issues since it is not clear that wealthy blacks, the black middle class, and the black poor share cultural traits that they do not share with many nonblacks
 - The black poor/middle class are those who are taken to have the ‘authentic’ black experience
 - Gender differences
 - But all blacks still face antiblack racism and can unite on this without a common identity
 - Shelby thinks that Blacks, taken in the thin sense, are clearly an ethnically and culturally diverse group; this diversity includes differences in physical appearance, language, customs, religion, political outlook, moral and aesthetic values, cuisines, fashion, national origins etc
 - Even if we can create a nuanced, nonmonolithic version of thick blackness, drawing the line somewhere would still exclude some blacks from laying claim to having an “authentic” black experience → unnecessary and interminable debate over what counts as black and who will decide
- Common oppression without that eschews the requirement of a collective black identity
 - One can acknowledge the importance of learning about black history and understanding black cultures without treating cultural blackness, however delimited, as defining who one is or allowing it to set the boundaries of one’s choices

Spencer’s Biological Realism

Central Thesis: debunk the view that folk racial classification has no biological basis and suggests that that race does pick out a biologically real entity. Spencer suggests that ‘race’ is not a kind term but instead a proper name for a set of human population groups and that human genetic clustering results show that an objective, biological partition is plausible

- Theory of reference

- Model a term's meaning as just its referent: If by using appropriate evidential methods one finds that a term *t* has a logically inconsistent set of identifying conditions but a robust extension, then it is appropriate to identify the measuring of *t* as just its referent
- Racial discourse: Office of Management and Budget revised its race talk to the five racial groups America uses today so the US racial discourse is controlled by a linguistic division of labour, Putnam would argue that when Americans engage in national racial discourse, they are semantically deferring to the OMB as the experts on race
 - OMB intends to pick out a set with 'race' → referred to race as a set of categories six times → a minimum set of categories for data on race but will also permit the collection of more detailed information of population groups provided that any additional categories can be aggregated into the minimum standard set of categories
- Race as a Human Population Partition
 - Genetic clustering analysis to make an educated guess about local populations in the target species → use ethnic groups to estimate local population structure in humans
 - Partition the sample into $N-1$ levels of partitions such that the partitions at each level is the unique partition that minimises genetic differences in parts and maximises genetic differences among parts, where N is the number of objects being partitions
 - No partitions may be found if the sampled individuals are too closely related or have too much admixture or form a panmictic unit
 - The Blumenbach partition of $K=5$ races is just the US partition of race → each race term in US racial discourse is just an alias for a unique Blumenbachian population + three reasons for believing that Americans are really just talking about Blumenbachian populations
 - Extensional overlap between current extensions of US race terms and Blumenbachian population terms is statistically significant
 - Definite Descriptions Americans use to pick out US races also pick out unique Blumenbachian populations → descriptions work well precisely because they can be explained by the historical essences of Blumenbachian populations along with a few facts about human evolutionary history
 - OMB uses "having origins in any of the original peoples of Hawaii, Guam, Samoa or other Pacific Islands" as a definite description for Pacific Islanders
 - But of course the description also picks out Oceanians and if Pacific Islanders just are Oceanians, we can explain why the definite description works so well to identify Pacific Islanders

- Counterfactual cases: there can be a possible world that support the claim that US race terms are just aliases for Blumenbachian populations
 - Consider a possible world *w* where human history unfolded exactly how it did in our world except that every Caucasian in *w* was killed by a disease in 2013 → given we use white in its national American meaning and we use Caucasian in its Blumenbachian meaning, it is fair to say that Caucasian and White are empty terms in *w* in 2014
 - Makes sense if white is just an alias for Caucasians
- Objections
 - Semantic objection: races must satisfy certain ordinary criteria in order to be races (be visible, discrete or isolated or differ in cognitive traits) but Blumenbachian populations do not satisfy all of those criteria noncontingently
 - Spencer: these criteria only seem to be part of the US meaning of race even though they are not since the meaning of race is just its referent
 - Semantic objection: Glasgow says that there is significant mismatch and that genetic clusters do not overlap ordinary US racial groups, especially if one asks “open-ended” questions about race
 - Whether Arab Americans would really identify as white and whether Hispanics would identify with any census race
 - Spencer: overlap in question is not only high; relevant question is not whether Arabs, Hispanics etc would identify with a census race if asked what their race is → relevant question is whether they would identify with a census race in the context of national racial discourse
 - Arab Americans can identify as Arab among friends and family but White when filling up national census or job applications
 - Metaphysical objection: Race must still be a “fundamental and primitive” category to be considered “biologically real” → races must be significantly different between one another to be meaningful biological units → Blumenbach populations are not fundamental to population genetics, are not subspecies and are not genetically very different
 - Spencer: entities need not be important to be real like the element 117 is not important in chemistry but is still “real”
 - Reply: Naomi Zack defines “real entities” in science as ones that occupy “a world that exists independently of thought, sensation, perception, language, and other symbolic representation”
 - Human group differences are only biologically real only if they are not culturally constructed

- Spencer objects to this since cultural evolution is relevant to the origin and persistence of biological entities and asks us to consider the Blumenbach partition which cannot be explained by mind-independent factors (but Spencer's reply here is obviously circular!) due to social isolation mechanism to foster inbreeding